18TH-CENTURY BRITISH SHIP OF THE LINE

HMS VICTORY

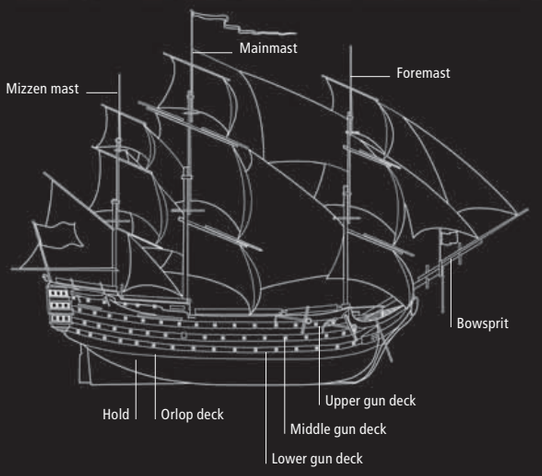
HER ROLE AS HORATIO NELSON'S FLAGSHIP at the battle of Trafalgar in 1805 made *Victory* the world's most famous first-rate ship of the line. Preserved as a museum ship at Portsmouth, England, she is now also the oldest commissioned naval vessel. *Victory* was a typical warship of its time, although one of the largest in the Royal Navy.

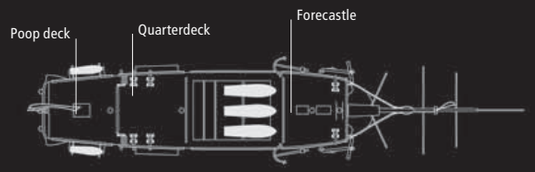
MORE THAN 6,000 trees, mostly oak, were felled for *Victory*'s construction. She cost £63,175 to build, probably equivalent to US $100 million today. This expensive ship was launched in 1765, but was not commissioned until war with France broke out in 1778. She saw her first action as the flagship of Admiral Keppel at the battle of Ushant in that year and was notably Admiral John Jervis's flagship at the battle of Cape St. Vincent in 1797. By that time *Victory* was showing her age and was retired to serve as a hospital ship for prisoners of war. This decision was, however, soon reconsidered. After extensive repair and reconstruction, *Victory* was recommissioned as Nelson's flagship in 1803, remaining in active service until 1812.

Victory was operated by a crew of 850 men and mounted 104 smoothbore, muzzle-loading cannon (including four carronades). Even with solid shot, this was formidable firepower—for comparison, at the great battle of Austerlitz in the same year as Trafalgar, the entire French Army fielded 139 cannon.

Sailing for the Downs
HMS *Victory* sails past Dover on her way to the Downs. Sailors can be seen high in the rigging lowering topgallant sails, while lower down a course sail is unfurled on the mainmast.







HMS Victory
Launched on May 7, 1765, *Victory* was a first-rate ship of the line with three gun decks. The decks were 186 ft (57 m) long and the ship was 52 ft (16 m) wide at its broadest point. The masts and spars supported a total of 37 sails.



» Figurehead
Victory's figurehead shows two cupids supporting the royal coat of arms (then featuring the escutcheon of Hanover) surmounted by a crown. The arms are surrounded by the motto of the Order of the Garter, "Honi soit qui mal y pense" ("Shame on he who thinks evil of it").



» Ship's name
Nelson's flagship at Trafalgar was the sixth Royal Navy ship to bear the name *Victory*. The first was a 42-gun ship originally called *Great Christopher* and purchased by the Royal Navy in 1569.



« Stern galleries
The rear of the ship housed the cabins of the admiral, the captain, and other senior officers. The stern of *Victory* was less decorated than earlier ships of her kind.

> "THE DEAD LAY ALONG THE DECKS IN HEAPS ... MORE THAN FOUR HUNDRED HAD BEEN KILLED AND WOUNDED ... AN EXTRAORDINARY PROPORTION HAD LOST THEIR HEADS."
>
> **CAPTAIN JAMES ATCHERLY**, DESCRIBING THE CARNAGE ABOARD *BUCENTAURE* AFTER HER ENGAGMENT WITH *VICTORY* AT TRAFALGAR